



PATH 14

A small AI membership

The vault must stay useful if they never attend a call.

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Who this is for

You can show up monthly with updated workflows after the one-time product has sold.

First sale

Three members who stay past month one.

Time to first

After you have buyers

Cash window

\$9-\$19/month

Tools

Leave this alone

Stripe subscriptions or Stan, a simple member page. A \$99/month room with nothing inside. Launching this before the one-time product has sold.

What this actually is

A small membership is a vault that stays useful if they never attend a call. That sentence is the whole design. Updates. New templates. A monthly workflow when the models change. Not your personality, unless you can keep that promise on a tired Thursday in February.

Members already bought the one-time file — the playbook, the prompt stack, the template pack — and the tools moved. A setting changed. A prompt that used to work got mushy. The membership is the living layer on top of a product that already earned trust.

This is a second product. It is not a way to avoid finishing the first one. A \$99 room with a Discord and a promise is a leak. A \$9 vault with three real files and a cancel button that works is a quiet till.

Cancel anytime. Earn the next month. Those two rules keep you honest. Live is optional garnish. The vault is the meal. Price sits in a band a person can keep without a meeting with themselves: **\$9–\$19 a month.**

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you already have buyers of a one-time file and you can name, in one sentence, what those buyers still need after they finish the PDF. It fits if you already update your own workflows when the tools move, and writing that down would take a morning, not a new personality.

It also fits if you can stand a monthly rhythm: a dated note, a new file, a short list of what changed. If you vanish for eight weeks, you should already have decided how you refund the unused month.

Skip this if

Skip it if the one-time product has not sold. Skip it if you want a membership so you do not have to ship a finished file. Skip it if the only offer is 'community' and a chat that goes quiet at 4pm. Skip it if they must attend a call for the thing to be worth \$9. They will not attend. They will still want the file.

Skip the \$99 version until people already stay at \$9. High price does not create value. It creates refunds and a room you dread. If people already email 'did this still work after the model update,' you are holding the membership in your inbox.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this on a card: **\$9 a month for the updates the [book / stack / template] does not get.**

New workflow when the tools change. Cancel anytime. If you cannot say what the updates are, you do not have an offer.

What members get that the file does not

The dated workflow for this month's model behavior — what broke, what you changed, the prompt or SOP that replaces last quarter's version.

New templates or checklists that did not exist when they bought the file.

A short archive they can search on a Sunday, not a chat scroll.

Optional: a monthly office-hours slot if you can keep it when you are tired. If you cannot, do not list it.

What they do not get

Not a second brain on Slack. Not custom work inside the \$9. Not you hiding the one-time product so the only door is a subscription. The file stays for sale. People who only want the file should still be able to buy it and leave.

Checkout line: \$9/month for updates the book does not get. Three files in the vault on day one. Cancel anytime. If I vanish, you get the unused month back.

What done looks like

Done for launch is not a hundred members. Done is:

The one-time file has sold to real buyers.

You wrote what members get that the book does not.

Three items are in the vault before anyone is charged. Not ‘coming soon.’

Price is **\$9–\$19**. Checkout works. Cancel is one or two clicks, not a guilt form.

You invited existing buyers first, with a true sentence.

Done for the first season is **three members who stay past month one**. Ten people who cancel on day 28 means the vault was a teaser. Three people still there on day 45 means you earned the second month.

A month is done when the note went out: what changed in the tools, what file you added, where it lives. If you hosted a call, a recording or the written version is in the vault within 48 hours. If you did not host a call, the vault still got the file. The call was never the product.

Pricing and the cash window

\$9–\$19 a month. \$9 is the default. \$19 is for a vault that already has a back catalog — six months of workflows, not three PDFs and a smile.

A person who already paid \$19–\$47 for your file can keep \$9 without a story. \$29 starts to feel like another product they have to justify. \$99 is a different business: more support, more presence, more ways to fail them. Do not collect \$99 for a Discord you check twice a week.

Annual can wait. If you offer it, **10 months for the price of 12** is plenty — \$90 for the year at the \$9 level. Do not discount monthly to ‘fill seats.’ There are no seats. There is a vault.

Three members at \$9 is \$27 a month. That is a signal, not rent. Ten is \$90. Thirty is \$270, which starts to pay for the morning you spend on the note. The cash window opens **after you have buyers**. Charge on the same date. Send the update in the same week. If you cannot support more people, cap it. Scarcity should be your calendar, not a fake ‘3 spots left’ on a folder.

The first 72 hours

Do not spend 72 hours touring community platforms. Spend it on the vault and the sentence.

Hours 1–3: the gap list

Open the one-time file. List what it cannot do after a model change. List questions buyers already asked. Circle three items you can finish this week: a revised prompt, a new checklist, a one-page ‘what broke in [month]’ workflow. Those three are the vault.

Hours 4–8: the page and the price

One member page. What they get. What they do not. Price \$9. Cancel anytime. Refund the unused month if you vanish — write that down. Stripe or Stan. Buy it from a second email. Cancel it. If cancel takes a support ticket, you built a trap.

Day 2–3: files and invites

Name files like jobs: ‘2026-08-workflow-client-follow-up,’ not ‘Update!!’. A two-line index: file, date, job. Then write to people who already paid. Not a public launch. Ten invites beat a hundred strangers. The book stays as it is; this is the living layer; \$9; cancel anytime; here are the three files.

Gap list from the file and from real questions

\$9, working cancel, self-test

Three vault items with job-shaped names

Invites to existing buyers only

The path, step by step

Step 1. Sell the one-time file first. Membership is a second product for people who already trust you. If path 1 has not sold, go back.

Step 2. Write what members get that the book does not. Dated workflows, new templates, the monthly note. If the paragraph is about your energy or your ‘space,’ start again with files.

Step 3. Vault first, calls optional. Build the folder as if nobody will ever attend a Zoom. If you add a call later, the recap lands in the vault within two days.

Step 4. Three items in the vault before the door opens. Not a roadmap. Not a welcome video promising the roadmap. Three files they can use tonight.

Step 5. Price \$9–\$19 and make cancel easy. Test it yourself. Write the vanish/refund rule on the page so you are stuck with your own standard.

Step 6. Invite existing buyers first. Ten personal notes. Public launch only after three people have stayed, or at least paid without asking ‘wait, what is this.’

Step 7. A monthly note with two headings. What changed in the tools. What file you added. Date it. Under a page. Miss it twice and you are running a ghost charge.

Step 8. Answer in the vault, not in private exception. A good question becomes a file everyone gets. Custom work belongs in a paid project, not inside \$9.

Step 9. Cap when your calendar says so. If you cannot read the replies or you are slipping the note, close new signups. A fake counter is a trick. A real cap is a number you can host.

Step 10. Keep selling the one-time file. Do not hide it to milk the subscription. The file is how new members appear.

Step 11. Earn month two on purpose. At day 20, look at the vault as a member would. Is there a reason to stay besides inertia? If not, add the file now, not on day 31 after they cancel.

Step 12. Review stay-rate at day 45. Three members still there is a working path. A pile of day-7 cancels means the listing overpromised. Fix the files. Do not raise the price to make up for churn.

A worked example: Avery’s \$9 vault

Avery sold a \$27 playbook: a 10-day content system for one-person landscaping companies. Forty-ish buyers. Then the model started ignoring the ‘keep it local, no corporate voice’

constraint. Buyers emailed. Avery answered the same reply for free, forever.

The membership was not a community. One sentence: **\$9/month for updates the book does not get. Cancel anytime.** The vault opened with three items: (1) the revised prompt stack tested that week, (2) a one-page ‘what changed in the tools this month’ note, (3) a seasonal winter checklist the original file never had.

No Discord. No calls on the page. Avery knew February would be tired. Invites went to existing buyers only. Twelve notes. Five joined the first week. One canceled on day 6 because they wanted custom captions — Avery refunded, pointed them at a productized service, and did not chase. By day 45, three were still there. That matched the first-sale line.

On the first Tuesday of each month Avery spent two hours: rerun the core workflow on a real landscaping example, write what broke, drop a file named by month and job. The \$27 file stayed on the site. Members who never opened the email still had the file in the vault.

Month 4: six workflows, two extra checklists, fourteen members, about \$126 a month. Enough to pay for the morning and to stop giving updates away in a messy inbox. A member asked for a live critique. Avery said no inside the \$9 and offered a one-time package at the freelance rate. The vault stayed a vault.

What Avery refused: a \$99 ‘inner circle,’ a fake countdown, hiding the playbook, and a call schedule that would collapse the first week a job ran long.

Copy you can paste

Checkout line

\$9/month for updates the book does not get. Cancel anytime.

Invite to an existing buyer

You already have [file name]. The tools already moved. I am keeping a \$9 vault with the dated workflows the PDF cannot get. Three files are in there today, including [name the most useful

one]. Cancel anytime. If I disappear, I refund the unused month. The original file stays yours either way.

Public listing, only after buyers have joined

The [file] is a one-time buy. This membership is the update layer: monthly workflow when the models change, new templates, cancel anytime. Built for people who already use the file. \$9/month.

Monthly note

Subject: [Month] vault — what changed, what I added

What changed in the tools: [one paragraph, named model or setting].

What I added: [file name, job it does, where it sits].

What I am not doing this month: [a call / a new niche / custom reviews].

Good questions become next month's file. Custom work is a separate package.

Vanish policy, on the page

Cancel in two clicks from the billing portal. If I go quiet for 30 days without a note, email me and I refund the unused month. I will not hide the button.

Week-by-week

This path does not start in week 1 of your business. It starts **after the one-time file has sold**.

Week 0 (gate). Confirm you have buyers and a list of questions they already asked. If you do not, stop and go sell the file.

Week 1. Three vault items. Member page. \$9. Cancel tested. Invites to existing buyers only. No public thread. No Discord. No countdown.

Week 2. Point joins at the three files. If someone asks for custom, decline inside the membership and name the other path.

Week 3. First monthly note even if it has only been three weeks — pick a cadence (first Tuesday) and hit it. Add one file that came from a real question.

Week 4. Look at cancels. If everyone left, the vault was a teaser. Fix the files before you invite more. If three stayed, you have a path.

Weeks 5–8. Same Tuesday. Same two headings. Keep selling the one-time file. Mention the vault as a second product, not a replacement. Cap if replies turn into unpaid consulting.

Month 3. Count members, stay-rate past day 45, and whether the vault would still be useful if you never hosted a call. If yes, keep \$9. If you now have six-plus dated workflows, you may test \$19 for new members and grandfather the first ones.

Quality bar

The bar: **a member who never attends a call still got something they can run this month.** If that is false, you are charging for a room.

Floor

Three real files on day one, named by job and date.

A monthly note that names tools, not vibes. ‘The follow-up prompt started hedging; here is the blunt version’ beats ‘lots of exciting changes.’

Cancel works without a performance.

The one-time product remains for sale and remains true.

Support

\$9 buys files and a monthly note, not a private desk. Reply to questions that improve the vault. A 48-hour window on weekdays is enough. Custom deliverables get a no and a link to a package.

Calls, if you even have one

One optional session a month, same hour, recorded or written up. Miss it rather than ship a bad one. Never make attendance the only way to get the value. If you are tired, skip the call and write

the file.

What to measure

Invites sent to existing buyers. If this is zero, you launched to the void.

Join rate from those invites. Five from twelve notes is a warm file.

Members who stay past month one. Three is a working vault.

Day-45 stay-rate. Stayers divided by people who had a chance to be charged twice. Under 40% means the vault did not earn the second month.

Monthly note shipped on time. A binary. Missed notes predict churn.

Files added per month. One is enough. Zero is a ghost charge.

Custom requests inside the \$9. If they rise, your copy is fuzzy or you are too available.

Revenue after refunds. Do not screenshot gross joins.

Do not measure Discord online count or likes on the announcement. Measure whether they kept paying after they saw the folder.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

‘I should charge \$99 so people take it seriously.’ People take files seriously. They take a \$99 empty room as a mistake. Earn \$9 first. Raise when the archive is fat.

‘I need a community for this to work.’ You need a vault. Ten quiet downloaders beat a hundred lurkers in a dead chat. If you want a group, that is a different path.

‘Buyers will be mad updates were not in the original file.’ Tell the truth: the file is the job as of a date. The vault is the living layer. You sold a complete file and you are offering a continuation.

‘Nobody wants another subscription.’ True for bad ones. False for \$9 that saves them from re-solving a broken prompt every time a model shifts. Easy cancel respects the fatigue.

‘I will launch this to grow my audience.’ Backwards. The audience of buyers already exists. A membership with no file behind it is a chat room with a card on file.

‘What if I cannot keep it up?’ Then do not open it. Or open it with the vanish rule already on the page. A clean refund is better than a silent charge.

What feeds this path

The one-time file. New buyers are the only honest top of funnel. Mention the vault once after they have the file, not as a popup on page one.

Buyer questions. Inbox, checkout comments, ‘does this still work.’ Each repeated question is next month’s file. If nobody asks anything, you may need a clearer file, not a membership.

Tool changes. Model updates, UI moves, a setting that used to be default. Keep a running log. The monthly note writes itself from that log.

Your own weekly work. If you still run the system, the membership is the dated version of what you already had to fix. If you abandoned the job, the vault will rot.

What does not feed it. Cold ads to a \$9 vault. Affiliate blasts. ‘Join the movement’ threads. Other people’s mastermind screenshots.

Mistakes

Charging for a Discord that is dead. A quiet folder is a product. A quiet chat is a ghost town you billed.

Never updating. The charge continues. The vault does not. Set the monthly note on a calendar. If you skip, refund or extend. Do not hide.

Hiding the one-time product so you can milk a subscription. You starve the only source of members who already trust you.

Launching before the file has sold. You will pitch strangers a living layer on a book they never bought. No context, no trust.

Making calls the product. They will miss the call. You will miss the call. The vault should have been enough.

Fake scarcity. ‘12 spots’ on an infinite folder. People learn. Your calendar is the only honest cap.

Answering custom work inside \$9. You train members to treat the vault as a junior employee. Say no. Point to a package.

A guilt cancel. Two clicks. You earn the next month with files, not with friction.

Tools

Stripe subscriptions or Stan. One product, one price, one portal where they can cancel without emailing you a plea.

A simple member page. A logged-in folder, a locked Notion page, a Stan membership, a Circle space you actually update. The dumbest tool you will keep beats the pretty one you will abandon.

Dated file names. YYYY-MM-job. Searchable in six months.

Your existing email list of buyers. Not a new platform.

A calendar reminder for the monthly note. Same week, same two headings.

You do not need a mobile app, a points system, or a course platform. You do not need Zoom if you are not hosting. If you already sold the file on Gumroad or Stan, use their membership add-on if cancel stays easy. Moving people to a new login in week 1 is a way to lose them before they see the three files.

Checklist

Gate

One-time file has sold to people who are not you.

You can name what members get that the file does not.

You can keep a monthly note when you are tired.

Before anyone pays

Three vault items live, named by job and date.

Price \$9–\$19. Cancel tested from a second email.

Vanish/refund rule on the page. Calls optional. Vault useful either way.

Invite

Existing buyers first. Ten notes, not a public circus. File remains for sale.

Every month

Note: what changed, what file you added.

One new useful file, even if it is short.

Custom asks declined inside the \$9; general answers filed in the vault.

Cap if you cannot support more people. Day 45: count stayers. Three past month one is the first real sale of this path.

FAQ

Do I need a membership if my file is selling?

Only if buyers still need something after they finish it — usually because tools move or seasons change. Do not invent a subscription to look like a ‘real’ business.

Can I launch the membership and the file on the same day?

You can. You should not. You will split your finish energy and have no honest invite list. Sell the file. Answer the follow-up questions. Then open the vault.

What if I hate writing a monthly note?

Then do not open a membership. A quarterly bundle sold as a one-time update pack is allowed. Recurring billing is a promise.

Should I include a Discord?

Only if you will moderate it on a schedule and it is extra, not the product. Most \$9 vaults are better as a folder.

How do I handle a member who wants custom work?

Refund if they joined by mistake. Otherwise: no inside the membership, here is the package. Put the reusable part of their question in the vault.

What if the tools do not change that month?

Ship anyway. A seasonal file, a tighter SOP, a filled example you did not have in the book. Silence is the failure, not a quiet month in the industry.

Can I charge \$19 from day one?

If the vault already has a back catalog, yes. If it has three files, start at \$9. Grandfather early members when you raise.

What counts as vanishing?

You skipped the monthly note and added no file, and 30 days passed. Charge still ran. Refund the unused month without making them write an essay.

How many members is too many at \$9?

When you cannot keep the note on time or you are doing custom work to keep people. For a folder-only vault, that number can be high. For a vault plus replies, it might be 30.

Do I remove people who never log in?

No. They paid for access, not for your feelings about engagement. They may log in the month something breaks. Measure stay-rate, not nag-rate.